

Advanced Learners' Use of Mobile Devices for English Language Study

Evaluation corpus document prepared for the Glyph RAG pipeline evaluation.

1. Study Overview

The study examines how advanced English language learners use mobile devices for English study. The participants were 20 Polish university students studying English philology. Data were collected through semi-structured interviews and analyzed using qualitative and quantitative approaches.

2. Learner Autonomy

Learner autonomy is described as the ability to take charge of one's own learning. The literature reviewed in the study also treats autonomy as involving decision-making, critical reflection, independent action, and control over learning. Autonomy is not presented as an all-or-nothing condition; it can vary across people, settings, skills, and circumstances.

3. Research Question and Participants

The study asks whether students use mobile devices to develop formal or informal English-learning experiences that meet their needs and goals, and, if so, why and how they do this. The participants included second- and third-year BA students and second-year MA students. Their English proficiency ranged from approximately B1-B2 through C1-C2 depending on the group.

4. Data Collection

The researcher used semi-structured interviews. This format combines prepared guiding questions with opportunities for participants to elaborate on issues that arise during the interview. Participants were encouraged to describe their own experiences using mobile devices for English study and gave permission for the interviews to be digitally recorded.

5. Reasons for Using Mobile Devices

Participants commonly described mobile devices as convenient, fast, and readily available. Smartphones and tablets provided quick internet access, allowed learners to organize study materials, and made dictionaries and other resources accessible without carrying physical books.

6. Resources and Tools

Participants used online dictionaries and mobile applications such as Google Translate, Duolingo, and Fiskoteka. Other resources included Voscreen, WhatsApp, TED, online newspapers, YouTube, 6 Minute English, PONS, and downloaded PDF materials. These resources were used for vocabulary, reading, listening, communication, and access to language-learning materials.

7. When Mobile Devices Were Used

Thirteen participants (65%) said they used mobile devices most frequently during leisure time, six (30%) primarily in the classroom, and one reported equal use in both settings. In informal learning, devices were used for reading English texts, listening to audio, learning vocabulary, preparing presentations, and playing language games. Classroom use often focused on checking unfamiliar words, spelling, collocations, or synonyms.

8. Formal and Informal Learning

Thirteen participants (65%) favored mobile devices for informal English learning, while seven (35%) associated their use primarily with formal learning. Only two participants described having somewhat regular, organized mobile-based English-learning sessions. Teachers did not explicitly require students to use mobile devices or recommend particular mobile applications during the classes described in the study.

9. Language Areas Practiced

All participants reported using mobile devices to practice English vocabulary. Some also used them for pronunciation, while relatively few used them for grammar, reading, listening, or speaking. Vocabulary was popular because mobile tools provided quick access to words, example contexts, spelling, pronunciation, and phonetic information.

10. Perceived Study Performance and Conclusions

Fifteen participants (75%) believed mobile devices encouraged them to study English more or helped them learn more effectively or efficiently. Five participants (25%) were unable to say whether mobile devices improved their effectiveness. The study concludes that mobile devices supported autonomous learning through convenience, access to resources, portability, and perceived learning benefits, while noting that the small and relatively homogeneous sample limits generalizability.